

Nonprofit and NGO English Jargon Quick Reference

Field-specific terms, contrast pairs, and high-pressure sentence frames

Audience: nonprofit program managers, NGO staff, grant writers, development officers, monitoring and evaluation teams, field coordinators, volunteer managers, and nonprofit executives

Focus: A nonprofit and NGO English curriculum for donor communication, grants, program evaluation, field operations, safeguarding, community partnerships, volunteer management, and mission-versus-budget tradeoffs.

Designed for advanced ESL learners who already use professional English and need industry-specific terminology, realistic meetings, role-play pressure, careful pushback, and polished workplace outputs.

Teaching stance: this is language and workplace-communication training, not legal, medical, financial, safety, or regulatory advice. Instructors should connect every scenario to the learner's current company policies, local rules, and approved procedures.

Nomenclature and Jargon

These are classroom working definitions. Learners should adapt wording to their organization's policies, systems, and local regulatory environment.

Mission, Theory of Change, and Program Design

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
mission	In nonprofit and ngo, mission is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to connect mission language to measurable program logic.	clarify mission; document mission	Contrast: mission should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify mission and the evidence that supports it.
theory of change	In nonprofit and ngo, theory of change is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to connect mission language to measurable program logic.	clarify theory of change; document theory of change	Contrast: theory of change should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify theory of change and the evidence that supports it.
output	In nonprofit and ngo, output is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to connect mission language to measurable program logic.	clarify output; document output	Contrast: output should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify output and the evidence that supports it.
outcome	In nonprofit and ngo, outcome is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to connect mission language to measurable program logic.	clarify outcome; document outcome	Contrast: outcome should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify outcome and the evidence that supports it.

Grant Proposals and Donor Restrictions

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
restricted funding	In nonprofit and ngo, restricted funding is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to write compelling proposals while respecting restrictions.	clarify restricted funding; document restricted funding	Contrast: restricted funding should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify restricted funding and the evidence that supports it.
deliverable	In nonprofit and ngo, deliverable is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to write compelling proposals while respecting restrictions.	clarify deliverable; document deliverable	Contrast: deliverable should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify deliverable and the evidence that supports it.
grant proposal	In nonprofit and ngo, grant proposal is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to write compelling proposals while respecting restrictions.	clarify grant proposal; document grant proposal	Contrast: grant proposal should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify grant proposal and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
mission fit	In nonprofit and ngo, mission fit is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to write compelling proposals while respecting restrictions.	clarify mission fit; document mission fit	Contrast: mission fit should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify mission fit and the evidence that supports it.

Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
indicator	In nonprofit and ngo, indicator is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss impact evidence without overclaiming.	clarify indicator; document indicator	Contrast: indicator should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify indicator and the evidence that supports it.
baseline	In nonprofit and ngo, baseline is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to discuss impact evidence without overclaiming.	clarify baseline; document baseline	Contrast: baseline should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify baseline and the evidence that supports it.
attribution	In nonprofit and ngo, attribution is a defined information asset or analytical construct used to measure, explain, or predict an outcome. Use it when teams need to discuss impact evidence without overclaiming.	clarify attribution; document attribution	Contrast: attribution should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify attribution and the evidence that supports it.
learning agenda	In nonprofit and ngo, learning agenda is a structured course of action that assigns priorities, sequencing, assumptions, and responsible roles. Use it when teams need to discuss impact evidence without overclaiming.	clarify learning agenda; document learning agenda	Contrast: learning agenda should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify learning agenda and the evidence that supports it.

Field Operations and Partner Coordination

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
implementing partner	In nonprofit and ngo, implementing partner is a stakeholder category whose needs, eligibility, experience, or obligations affect the decision. Use it when teams need to communicate operational risk in community settings.	clarify implementing partner; document implementing partner	Contrast: implementing partner should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify implementing partner and the evidence that supports it.
field visit	In nonprofit and ngo, field visit is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to communicate operational risk in community settings.	clarify field visit; document field visit	Contrast: field visit should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify field visit and the evidence that supports it.
contingency	In nonprofit and ngo, contingency is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to communicate operational risk in community settings.	clarify contingency; document contingency	Contrast: contingency should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify contingency and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
community trust	In nonprofit and ngo, community trust is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to communicate operational risk in community settings.	clarify community trust; document community trust	Contrast: community trust should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify community trust and the evidence that supports it.

Safeguarding and Incident Reporting

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
safeguarding	In nonprofit and ngo, safeguarding is a repeatable control mechanism used to prevent, detect, or confirm conditions before work proceeds. Use it when teams need to escalate sensitive concerns with care.	clarify safeguarding; document safeguarding	Contrast: safeguarding should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify safeguarding and the evidence that supports it.
confidentiality	In nonprofit and ngo, confidentiality is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to escalate sensitive concerns with care.	clarify confidentiality; document confidentiality	Contrast: confidentiality should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify confidentiality and the evidence that supports it.
survivor-centered	In nonprofit and ngo, survivor-centered is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to escalate sensitive concerns with care.	clarify survivor-centered; document survivor-centered	Contrast: survivor-centered should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify survivor-centered and the evidence that supports it.
incident report	In nonprofit and ngo, incident report is a workplace communication artifact that records facts, interpretation, and the decision or action requested. Use it when teams need to escalate sensitive concerns with care.	assess incident report; mitigate incident report	Contrast: incident report identifies a possible or current exposure; it is not the same as accepting that exposure. Example: We need to assess incident report, name the owner, and agree on the trigger for escalation.

Volunteer Management and Training

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
volunteer role	In nonprofit and ngo, volunteer role is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to set expectations for volunteers without discouraging them.	clarify volunteer role; document volunteer role	Contrast: volunteer role should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify volunteer role and the evidence that supports it.
training	In nonprofit and ngo, training is a capability or authorization process used to prepare, verify, or document that a person can perform a role. Use it when teams need to set expectations for volunteers without discouraging them.	clarify training; document training	Contrast: training should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify training and the evidence that supports it.
supervision	In nonprofit and ngo, supervision is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to set expectations for volunteers without discouraging them.	clarify supervision; document supervision	Contrast: supervision should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify supervision and the evidence that supports it.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
duty of care	In nonprofit and ngo, duty of care is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to set expectations for volunteers without discouraging them.	clarify duty of care; document duty of care	Contrast: duty of care should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify duty of care and the evidence that supports it.

Advocacy, Public Messaging, and Neutrality

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
advocacy	In nonprofit and ngo, advocacy is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to communicate advocacy positions responsibly.	clarify advocacy; document advocacy	Contrast: advocacy should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify advocacy and the evidence that supports it.
campaign	In nonprofit and ngo, campaign is a communication or market-facing element that must match evidence, audience, channel, and approval boundaries. Use it when teams need to communicate advocacy positions responsibly.	clarify campaign; document campaign	Contrast: campaign should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify campaign and the evidence that supports it.
dignity	In nonprofit and ngo, dignity is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to communicate advocacy positions responsibly.	clarify dignity; document dignity	Contrast: dignity should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify dignity and the evidence that supports it.
source	In nonprofit and ngo, source is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to communicate advocacy positions responsibly.	clarify source; document source	Contrast: source should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify source and the evidence that supports it.

Board Reporting and Sustainability

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
board governance	In nonprofit and ngo, board governance is a decision-accountability mechanism that clarifies who recommends, approves, performs, and accepts risk. Use it when teams need to present program and financial reality without panic.	clarify board governance; document board governance	Contrast: board governance should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify board governance and the evidence that supports it.
cash runway	In nonprofit and ngo, cash runway is a measurable indicator used to quantify performance, exposure, capacity, quality, or change over time. Use it when teams need to present program and financial reality without panic.	track cash runway; explain a change in cash runway	Contrast: cash runway measures a result or condition; it does not, by itself, prove the cause. Example: Before we act, let us track cash runway by segment and explain what changed.

Term	Working meaning	Collocations	Contrast and workplace line
reserve	In nonprofit and ngo, reserve is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to present program and financial reality without panic.	clarify reserve; document reserve	Contrast: reserve should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify reserve and the evidence that supports it.
scenario	In nonprofit and ngo, scenario is a field-specific concept used to locate the relevant fact, boundary, or decision variable. Use it when teams need to present program and financial reality without panic.	clarify scenario; document scenario	Contrast: scenario should be defined against the relevant evidence and decision boundary, rather than used as a vague label. Example: Before we proceed, please clarify scenario and the evidence that supports it.

Industry-Specific Meeting Moves

Situation	Useful language
Mission, Theory of Change, and Program Design	Before we commit, I want to confirm mission, theory of change, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If inputs, activities, outputs, outcomes, assumptions, and evidence need alignment., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Grant Proposals and Donor Restrictions	Before we commit, I want to confirm restricted funding, deliverable, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If mission fit, restricted funds, capacity, and reporting obligations need review., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning	Before we commit, I want to confirm indicator, baseline, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If indicators, baseline, attribution, qualitative evidence, and limitations matter., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Field Operations and Partner Coordination	Before we commit, I want to confirm implementing partner, field visit, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If local constraints, safety, community trust, budget, and contingency planning matter., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Safeguarding and Incident Reporting	Before we commit, I want to confirm safeguarding, confidentiality, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If safeguarding policy, confidentiality, survivor-centered response, and investigation process apply., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Volunteer Management and Training	Before we commit, I want to confirm volunteer role, training, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If role scope, training, supervision, risk, and client dignity matter., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Advocacy, Public Messaging, and Neutrality	Before we commit, I want to confirm advocacy, campaign, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If source, context, dignity, legal status, and organizational position need review., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.
Board Reporting and Sustainability	Before we commit, I want to confirm board governance, cash runway, the owner, and the evidence behind the decision. If scenario planning, reserves, restricted funds, staffing, and mission impact need clarity., I recommend we document the risk and agree on the next step.

High-pressure pushback frames

- I understand the urgency. The risk is that we move faster than the evidence or process supports.
- I am not blocking the goal. I am naming the condition we need before the decision is safe and credible.
- If we accept this risk, we should name the owner, document the assumption, and define the trigger for escalation.
- That may be possible, but not under the current scope, timeline, or approval path.
- Let's separate what we know, what we assume, and what still needs confirmation.

Contrast Pairs

Do not confuse	Useful distinction
mission vs outcome	In mission, theory of change, and program design, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
restricted funding vs mission fit	In grant proposals and donor restrictions, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
indicator vs learning agenda	In monitoring, evaluation, and learning, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
implementing partner vs community trust	In field operations and partner coordination, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
safeguarding vs incident report	In safeguarding and incident reporting, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
volunteer role vs duty of care	In volunteer management and training, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
advocacy vs source	In advocacy, public messaging, and neutrality, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.
board governance vs scenario	In board reporting and sustainability, define whether the discussion is about the current fact pattern, the controlling process, the stakeholder pressure, or the final decision.